Czech-East German border. (An East German tank and rifle division were assigned to the reserves of the Soviet High Command but remained in barracks.)

With devastating zeal, a series of swift land and air movements crushed Czechoslovakia's defiance under the tracks of Russian tanks. Humiliated, Dubček was kicked out of office and reduced in rank to a low-level bureaucrat; while others purged from power were forced to eke out a living with tiring menial jobs.

As nations across the world denounced the invasion as a 'shameless act' of aggression, Honecker was horrified to discover that 1,189 East Germans had rallied in sympathy for Czechoslovakia. According to Stasi figures, 75 per cent of them were aged between 12 and 30 years old. In some areas, demonstrators were yanked away, then kicked, punched and beaten by police officers. In Berlin, when Frank Havemann and Hans Jurgen Uszkoreit – both 18 years old – painted the name Dubček on the facade of the central library, they, like many other youths, were sent to prison, followed by years of 'probation in socialist production'. Honecker gave the most forthright – and pointed – defence of the GDR's part in the Prague operation before the ninth plenary session of the Central Committee, where he trumpeted that 'revisionist and counter-revolutionaries' in Czechoslovakia had progressed so far that political means were not sufficient to protect the country from the grip of imperialism: 'International socialist solidarity had to be supported by military means.'4 He also turned the needle on suggestions that 'building bridges' and 'change through rapprochement' could have solved the Prague dilemma.5

The following year, economics took a more severe and direct grip on Erich Honecker's life. The long winter of 1968-69 – the coldest in years – demanded a considerable effort on the part of cooperative farmers, while there was a noticeable shortage of electrical power, gas and solid fuels – a disaster for any government, especially one working on strict planning.

At the tenth conference of the SED Central Committee, Honecker poured out his frustration by demanding comrades in the power and transportation industry draw the proper conclusions from the winter. 'Besides, there was a shortage of metallurgical products and other important raw materials in